G6

A Long Walk to Water

Session 1 — Two Lives, One Land

LEARNING GOAL

The student can describe Nya's and Salva's worlds, explain why the author tells their stories in parallel, and use at least two new vocabulary words.

Session Date: ____Sept 18th____ · Full class session

SETTING

Where in the World?

1

SOUTH SUDAN

Home village for both Nya and Salva

2

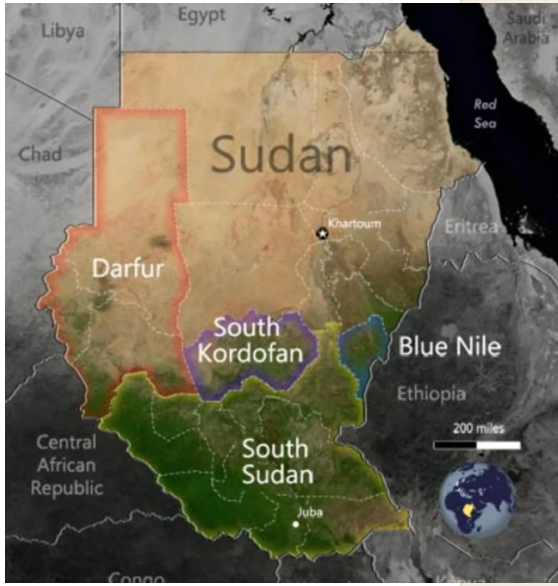
ETHIOPIA

Refugee camp on Salva's journey

3

KENYA

Kakuma refugee camp, later in Salva's story



Schematic route — not drawn to scale

FAST FACTS

- At the time of the story, Sudan was the largest country in Africa.
- A civil war (1983–2005) forced huge numbers of people — including many children known as “Lost Boys” — to flee on foot.
- Nya's family moves between two homes during the year to be near water and grazing land.

ROADMAP

Today's Session, Start to Finish

1 ~5 min

Warm-Up

Connect the story to your own life.

2 ~15 min

Read

Read four key passages from Chapters 1–2 together.

3 ~10 min

Solve

Discuss and interpret what you just read.

4 ~10 min

Memorize

Learn five new vocabulary words.

5 ~10 min

Test

Quick check: vocabulary and comprehension.

6 ~5 min

Wrap-Up

Write, reflect, and plan the next session.

Total ≈ 55 minutes — adjust the pace to fit your class length.

1 · WARM-UP

~5 min

Opening Conversation

Warm-Up Question

“If you had to walk a long way every day to get something your family needed, what would make that walk easier?”

Follow-up: Is there anything your own family has to work hard to get?

Today you will:

Read four key passages from Chapters 1–2, discuss them, learn new words, and take a short check.

TIP

The book alternates between two narrators. Before reading, make sure the student can keep Nya (2008) and Salva (1985) straight — who they are, where they are, and what each is doing.

Listen for:

- A specific reason, not just “a car.”
- A connection to the student's own life.

2 · READ (1 of 4)

Nya's Walk

SCENE — Southern Sudan, 2008 · opening of Chapter One

PDF page 7 — starts with: "Going was easy..."

Going, the big plastic container held only air. Tall for her eleven years, Nya could switch the handle from one hand to the other, swing the container by her side, or cradle it in both arms. She could even drag it behind her, bumping it against the ground and raising a tiny cloud of dust with each step.

There was little weight, going. There was only heat, the sun already baking the air, even though it was long before noon. It would take her half the morning if she didn't stop on the way.

Heat. Time. And thorns.

Describing Nya's walk to fetch water — the heat, the distance, and the empty container she carries.

While reading, ask:

What does this passage show about what Nya's body and day go through?

2 · READ (2 of 4)

Salva's Classroom & Family

SCENE — Southern Sudan, 1985 · Chapter One

PDF pages 7–9 — starts with: "Salva sat cross-legged…"

Salva sat cross-legged on the bench. He kept his head turned toward the front, hands folded, back perfectly straight. Everything about him was paying attention to the teacher—everything except his eyes and his mind.

His eyes kept flicking toward the window, through which he could see the road. The road home. Just a little while longer—a few minutes more— and he would be walking on that road.

… Salva's father was a successful man. He owned many head of cattle and worked as their village's judge—an honored, respected position. Salva had three brothers and two sisters. As each boy reached the age of about ten years, he was sent off to school.

Describing Salva in class, his father's position in the village, or his brothers' and sisters' roles.

While reading, ask:

What does this passage reveal about Salva's family's place in the community?

2 · READ (3 of 4)

Gunfire and Flight

SCENE — Southern Sudan, 1985 · end of Chapter One

PDF pages 10–11 — starts with: "CRACK! The noise had come from outside…"

Was it a gunshot? Or just a car backfiring? The teacher stopped talking for a moment. Every head in the room turned toward the window.

Nothing. Silence.

The teacher cleared his throat, which drew the boys' attention to the front of the room again. He continued the lesson from where he had left off.
Then—
CRACK! POP-POP-CRACK!

While reading, ask:

Why does the teacher tell the boys to run into the bush instead of home?

From the moment gunfire interrupts class and the teacher tells the students what to do.

2 · READ (4 of 4)

Alone in the Barn

SCENE — Southern Sudan, 1985 · end of Chapter Two

PDF page 16 — starts with: "Even before he was fully awake…"

,,,Salva could feel that something was wrong. He lay very still with his eyes closed, trying to sense what it might be.
Finally, he sat up and opened his eyes. No one else was in the barn.
Salva stood so quickly that for a moment he felt dizzy. He rushed to the door and looked out. Nobody. Nothing. They had left him. He was alone.

From the moment Salva wakes up in the barn and realizes what has happened.

While reading, ask:

Why is this moment such a turning point for Salva?

3 · SOLVE

~10 min

From Reading to Interpretation

1

How are Nya's day and Salva's day similar? How are they different?

2

What do we learn about Salva's family and community in Chapter One?

3

What does Nya's daily task suggest about what her family needs?

4

Why might the author choose to alternate between 1985 and 2008?

Teacher follow-up for every answer: "What in the text makes you think that?" — have the student locate the passage and explain it in their own words.

4 · MEMORIZE

~10 min

New Words: Part 1

S

Scarce

Not easily found; in short supply

PRACTICE

“Something that is scarce at my house is …”

D

Displaced

Forced to leave one's home

PRACTICE

How might it feel to be displaced from your home?

R

Routine

A fixed, regular way of doing something

PRACTICE

What is part of your morning routine?

4 · MEMORIZE

~10 min

New Words: Part 2

R

Resilient

Able to recover quickly from difficulty

PRACTICE

Describe a time you had to be resilient.

P

Parallel

Happening at the same time, alongside something else

PRACTICE

Why might an author tell two stories in parallel?

5 · TEST

~10 min

Quick Check

PART A — Vocabulary (say the best answer)

1. Scarce means — (a) not easily found (b) delicious (c) heavy

2. Displaced means — (a) proud (b) forced to leave home (c) tired

3. Resilient means — (a) able to recover from difficulty (b) angry (c) slow

4. Parallel means — (a) happening at the same time (b) far away (c) broken

PART B — Fill in the blank

5. Nya's family follows a strict daily _____ to fetch water.

6. After the attack, Salva and his neighbors were _____ from their village.

PART C — Short Answer (2–3 sentences each)

7. Why does the teacher tell the boys to run into the bush instead of going home?

8. What does Salva realize when he wakes up in the barn at the end of Chapter Two?

9. Why does the author tell Nya's and Salva's stories in parallel instead of one after the other?

6 · WRAP-UP

~5 min

Short Writing

Prompt

How are Nya's world and Salva's world alike, and how are they different?

1. Nya's world and Salva's world are _____ because _____.

2. For example, _____.

3. This suggests _____.

6 · WRAP-UP

Exit Ticket

E

Describe one difference between Nya's life and Salva's life using one new vocabulary word, and share one question about how their stories might connect.

HOMEWORK

- Read Chapter 3 (through the next Nya section)
- Write three original sentences using today's vocabulary
- Bring one discussion question to next session

SEE YOU NEXT SESSION

Chapter 3 — What happens next for Nya and Salva?

Bring your three sentences and your discussion question.